

Fellow academics defend LU dean against accusations of racism

David Lesbarrères stepped down as dean of graduate studies in June after tweet he later apologized for

10 h By: [Vicki Gilhula, Local Journalism Initiative reporter](#)

- https://www.sudbury.com/local-news/fellow-academics-defend-lu-dean-against-accusations-of-racism-2732380?utm_source=dlvr.it&utm_medium=facebook



David Lesbarrères. (Supplied)

Friends and colleagues of David Lesbarrères, the Laurentian University dean of graduate studies caught up in a controversy over a tweet in which he used the phrase “all lives matter,” are defending him against accusations that he is racist.

They are asking Laurentian administration to reinstate Lesbarrères and apologize for damaging his reputation.

"David is a wonderful guy who has been mistreated, and we need to address this injustice," says Jason Lepojarvi, an assistant professor of religious studies at Thorneloe University.

He didn't know Lesbarrères prior to the incident, but reached out to him because he sees him as a victim of cancel culture.

Cancel culture is defined as withdrawing support for people or businesses after they have done or said something considered objectionable or offensive.

[Lesbarrères left his position as dean two weeks after a June 8 tweet](#) in which he used the hashtag "#AllLivesMatters (sic)," and expressed his opinion that white men can be victims of racism.

Some of his Twitter account followers expressed hurt and anger, and as the tweet was reposted in social media, the hurt and anger multiplied.

On June 9, Lesbarrères removed the tweet and apologized on Twitter, "Last night, I issued a tweet that hurt many people. I apologize for my words and understand that I must educate myself further about #BlackLivesMatter and Tweeter (sic). I didn't know that # existed and now realize it is rooted in values I do not hold and that I strongly condemn.

"I pledge to continue to educate myself, continue the fight for inclusivity and against racism, and I apologize to all people I have hurt."

Laurentian University president Dr. Robert Haché immediately issued a response condemning the tweet as inappropriate and offensive.

In a statement on June 9, he said, "(I) wish to reiterate that I condemn any racism on campus. Laurentian is a campus that does its utmost to ensure that we are safe and inclusive."

Haché announced June 22 that Lesbarrères would be stepping down as dean of graduate studies "for an indeterminate period."

It is expected Lesbarrères will return to his previous position as an assistant professor in the department of biology, although he has no scheduled classes this term.

Lesbarrères' defenders believe he did not know the hashtag #AllLivesMatter is considered a criticism of the Black Lives Matter movement.

Aware speaking out in support of Lesbarrères could get him labelled as racist, Lepojarvi says the controversy clouds the real issues.

"When we go after a scapegoat like this, it undermines the respectable work against racism and it becomes counterproductive. It desensitizes the public.

"A great motivation to fix this injustice, which is painfully divisive, is because of general concerns for real racism and discrimination."

A petition in support of Lesbarrères was started by students, and about 180 students and faculty have signed it.

Guy Chamberland, chair of the department of ancient studies at Thorneloe, studied Lesbarrères' Twitter account dating back two years and found no evidence of racism.

He says it concerns him that the people calling Lesbarrères a racist do not see him as a human being with a record of supporting people of colour but simply "a white dude" of privilege.

Mery Martinez Garcia, a biology professor, is a member of an ad hoc committee on race created this summer by Laurentian administration.

"It is unfortunate that a tweet David wrote provoked the administration to finally take seriously that there is racial discrimination at Laurentian," says Martinez-Garcia, who is originally from Columbia.

"We all need to admit we are part of the problem and part of the solution."

Admitting being afraid of backlash for supporting her friend or being labelled as "a race traitor," she says, "David is a biologist who believes all life matters. People know David is not a racist but they are afraid to speak out. A lot of people forgot or don't care about all the things he has done for international students because of a tweet he wrote at 11 p.m. or whenever."

Charles Ramcharan, an assistant professor in the School of Environment, is originally from Trinidad. In defending Lesbarrères, he says any notion that there is not racism against whites is "bull"

His friend stepped on a "Twitter landmine," with two ill-considered tweets, says Ramcharan.

In a letter to Sudbury.com (to be published in the coming days), Ramcharan said, "David has been a strong voice for students who are black, Indigenous, and people of colour (BIPOC), an ally in the fight for equality, and a person in a position where his ideals and energies can be transformative.

"When his position was suspended, groups such as the Laurentian University African and Caribbean Students Association rushed to his defence ... They knew that David's convictions about equality were not just in the office.

"It's David who helped get Ontario Graduate Scholarships and Teaching Assistantships extended to international students. When COVID-19 forced the

campus to close, our Canadian students could safely return to their homes, but our foreign students were trapped here.

"These international students became David's responsibility and he worked tirelessly day and night to make sure that each one was well taken care of. When the campus residences were closed, David and his family housed an Iranian student until they could find another apartment. He also helped a refugee student find a safe Sudbury shelter home for his whole family."

"We are defending common sense and a good person. We (academics) are frightened, if this is how (they) treat people who make a mistake," says Lepojarvi.



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